

A Programmatic Framework for Modular Semantic Theory Development Using SMT Solvers

Author Name^{1*}

^{1*}Department, University, City, State, Country.

Corresponding author(s). E-mail(s): author@example.com;

Abstract

The development and comparative analysis of semantic theories—particularly hyperintensional and non-classical logics—has been hindered by the lack of systematic computational tools. We present MODELCHECKER, a programmatic framework that treats semantic theories as executable programs, compiling truth conditions into SMT constraints for automated model discovery. The theory-agnostic architecture enables rapid implementation of diverse semantic frameworks (classical, modal, temporal, truthmaker semantics) with systematic comparative analysis. Constraint-based exploration of finite models provides evidence for validity by ruling out small countermodels, leveraging Z3 solver efficiency. Computational tractability (solver performance, timeout rates, maximum model size) provides a rigorous, quantifiable measure of theoretical complexity, replacing subjective aesthetic evaluations with empirical metrics. The extensible THEORYLIB library of semantic theories supports modular composition, sharing, and citation to advance semantic research. We demonstrate implementation of four major semantic frameworks (LOGOS bilateral truthmaker semantics with 19 operators, EXCLUSION unilateral semantics, IMPOSITION counterfactual theory, BIMODAL temporal-modal logic) with over 177 validated examples. This represents the first systematic computational implementation of bilateral truthmaker semantics and demonstrates feasibility of programmatic semantic theory development at scale.

Keywords: automated reasoning, semantic theory, SMT solvers, truthmaker semantics, hyperintensional logic, model theory, Z3, modal logic

1 Introduction

1.1 The Challenge of Semantic Theory Development

Semantic theories have traditionally been developed through hand-constructed models and manual proofs. This approach carries significant limitations: difficulty verifying complex inference patterns across multiple operators, no systematic way to compare theories on identical test cases, barriers to entry for implementing emerging semantic frameworks, limited exploration of model space due to the burden of manual example construction, and validation bottlenecks where checking validity claims requires extensive manual computation prone to error.

Perhaps most significantly, theories are typically assessed via subjective aesthetic criteria—“elegance,” “simplicity,” “naturalness”—rather than empirical measures. Debates about theoretical complexity remain unresolved due to the lack of objective metrics. Different theorists may disagree profoundly about whether a theory is “simple” or “elegant.”

1.2 The Computational Turn in Semantics

Recent work in computational metaphysics and automated reasoning has demonstrated the value of applying formal verification tools to philosophical logic [1, 2]. These approaches have validated specific arguments and tested metaphysical theories, but have not provided general-purpose infrastructure for developing entire semantic frameworks.

1.3 Our Contribution

We present MODELCHECKER, a programmatic framework that:

1. **Compiles semantic theories to SMT constraints:** Truth conditions become executable Z3 constraints.
2. **Enables modular theory composition:** Operators loaded selectively with automatic dependency resolution.
3. **Supports systematic comparison:** Run identical examples across multiple semantic frameworks.
4. **Provides finite model exploration:** Constraint-based search through state spaces with configurable size.
5. **Implements TheoryLib:** Extensible library of semantic theories as reusable, citable components.
6. **Establishes objective complexity measures:** Computational tractability (solver performance, timeout rates, feasible model sizes) replaces subjective aesthetic evaluations with empirical, quantifiable metrics.

Paper Roadmap.

Section 2 presents the programmatic methodology, three-level architecture, and computational complexity of semantic primitives. Section 3 discusses modularity, extensibility, and systematic theory comparison. Section 4 covers finite model exploration and

countermodel methodology. Section 5 describes the theory-agnostic framework and THEORYLIB vision. Section 6 presents the LOGOS theory case study. Section 7 provides implementation results and validation. Section 8 surveys related work. Section 9 discusses future directions and conclusions.

2 The Programmatic Methodology

2.1 Three-Level Architecture

Semantic theories function as pipelines from syntax to models, organized across three distinct levels.

2.1.1 Level 1: Syntax Layer (Theory-Independent)

The syntax layer handles formula parsing from L^AT_EX notation to abstract syntax trees. The parser recognizes structural patterns without knowing operator semantics; AST nodes map to semantic implementation classes. This language-agnostic design means the same parser handles classical, modal, and hyperintensional operators.

2.1.2 Level 2: Semantics Layer (Theory-Specific Plugin)

Truth conditions generate Z3 formulas through an extensible evaluation point structure. The `eval_point` dictionary enables diverse semantic frameworks:

- Modal: `{"world": w}`
- Bimodal: `{"world": w, "time": t}`
- Hyperintensional: Access to both worlds and partial states

Operator interface patterns vary by theory type. Extensional theories implement `true_at(w, s, eval_point)`. Bilateral theories add `falsify`, `extended_verify`, and `extended_falsify`. Frame constraints encode structural semantic principles (e.g., transitivity of accessibility relations).

2.1.3 Level 3: Model Layer (Theory-Dependent Interpretation)

The Z3 solver finds satisfying assignments or proves unsatisfiability. Model extraction converts Z3's internal representation to semantic structures, and each theory defines how to interpret and display models.

Technical Example.

Consider the formula $\Box(A \rightarrow B)$ (necessity of conditional):

```

1 # Syntax Layer:
2 Parse: Necessity[Implication[A, B]]
3
4 # Semantics Layer (Modal):
5 # For all worlds w:
6 #   true_at(w, Box(A -> B)) <=> ForAll w'[R(w, w') -> true_at(w',
   A -> B)]

```

Table 1 Key Semantic Settings

Setting	Effect	Typical Use
N	State space size (2^N states)	3–6; larger for complex formulas
contingent	Require both verifiers and falsifiers	Force non-trivial propositions
non_empty	No empty verifier/falsifier sets	Exclude degeneracies
disjoint	No state both verifies and falsifies	Move toward classical logic
non_null	Null state doesn't verify/falsify	Structuralist assumptions
iterate	Find multiple distinct models	Explore model diversity

```

7
8 # Generates Z3 constraint:
9 ForAll([w_prime],
10     Implies(R(w, w_prime),
11         Implies(verify(w_prime, A),
12             verify(w_prime, B))))
13
14 # Model Layer:
15 # Z3 finds: {w0, w1, w2}, R = {(w0,w1), (w1,w2)},
16 #         verify(w1, A) = True, verify(w1, B) = True, ...

```

Listing 1 From formula to constraint

2.2 The Builder Pattern Orchestration

Three coordinating classes manage the complete pipeline.

BuildModule loads example files, manages theory selection, and coordinates multiple examples. It takes as input a Python module with **premises**, **conclusions**, and **settings**, producing results across all examples, optionally in multiple theories.

BuildExample executes the complete pipeline for a single example with a specific theory. The process includes: (1) parse formulas using the syntax layer, (2) instantiate theory-specific semantics, (3) generate Z3 constraints from semantic rules, (4) invoke solver with timeout, and (5) extract and format results. A fresh Z3 context per example prevents constraint contamination.

BuildProject generates new theory implementations as complete Python packages, with scaffolding including **semantic.py**, **operators.py**, **examples.py**, tests, and documentation.

2.3 Settings-Driven Semantic Control

The hierarchical configuration system (from highest to lowest priority) includes:

1. Command-line flags: **--contingent**, **--maximize**, **--save**
2. Example-specific settings: **settings** = {"N": 4, "iterate": 5}
3. Module **general_settings**: Apply to all examples in file
4. Theory defaults: **default_settings** in semantic class
5. System defaults: Framework-level fallbacks

Users can control semantic properties without modifying theory code, enabling exploration of variations (e.g., classical vs. non-classical) within a single framework.

2.4 Constraint Generation Process

Constraints fall into three categories:

Frame Constraints (3–5 per theory) define semantic structure independent of atomic propositions. Examples include “possible states closed downward” and “at least one world exists.” These are loaded once per theory instantiation.

Model Constraints (15–60 per example) are applied per atomic proposition in formulas. They control proposition behavior: fusion closure, classical constraints (`non_empty`, `disjoint`). The count scales with the number of sentence letters.

Evaluation Constraints (2–5 per example) encode specific example requirements: premises true at designated world(s), at least one conclusion false (for countermodel search).

A typical constraint count ranges from 20 to 130+ depending on formula complexity, number of atomic propositions, settings enabling optional constraints, and theory sophistication.

2.5 Computational Complexity of Semantic Primitives and Arity

The computational complexity of a semantic theory depends not only on how many Z3 primitives it declares, but critically on the *arity* (number of arguments) of those primitives and how they interact in constraints.

2.5.1 Objective Complexity Measurement

Traditional semantic theory evaluation relies heavily on subjective aesthetic criteria: “elegance,” “naturalness,” “parsimony,” and “intuitiveness.” These evaluations are inherently subjective and contested.

Computational complexity provides a rigorous, objective alternative. The tractability of a semantic theory—measured by solver performance, timeout rates, and maximum feasible model size—is an empirical fact, not an aesthetic judgment. A theory that times out at $N = 3$ is objectively more computationally complex than one tractable at $N = 6$, regardless of how “elegant” its formulation appears.

Key advantages of computational measures include: (1) empirical verification where complexity claims can be tested and replicated, (2) quantitative comparison where theories are ranked by measurable performance metrics, (3) theory-independence where the same benchmarks apply across different semantic frameworks, (4) predictive power where performance characteristics guide practical applicability, and (5) optimization guidance where specific sources of complexity are identified for targeted improvement.

2.5.2 Arity and Quantifier Complexity

Z3 function declarations have varying arity, which directly impacts quantifier structure:

```

1 # Unary functions (1 argument)
2 possible = z3.Function('possible', BitVecSort(N), BoolSort)
3 # Constraint: ForAll s[possible(s) -> ...] (1 quantifier)
4
5 # Binary functions (2 arguments)
6 verify = z3.Function('verify', BitVecSort(N), AtomSort, BoolSort)
7 # Constraint: ForAll s,A[verify(s,A) -> ...] (2 quantifiers)
8
9 # Ternary functions (3 arguments)
10 selection = z3.Function('selection', BitVecSort(N),
    BitVecSort(N), AtomSort, BoolSort)
11 # Constraint: ForAll w,w',A[selection(w,w',A) -> ...] (3
    quantifiers)

```

Listing 2 Primitive function arity

Each additional argument introduces another quantifier in constraints, increasing solver difficulty exponentially. Quantifier alternation is especially significant: $\forall s \forall A[\dots]$ is relatively tractable, while $\forall A[\exists s[\dots]]$ is much harder, and triple alternation $\forall w[\exists w'[\forall s[\dots]]]$ is very difficult.

2.5.3 Theory Comparison by Primitive Arity

Table 2 Comparative Analysis of Semantic Primitives

Theory	Primitive	Arity	Quantifier Pattern	Complexity
Classical	true_at	2	$\forall w \forall A(\dots)$	Moderate
Modal	accessible	2	$\forall w \forall w'(R(w, w') \rightarrow \dots)$	Moderate
LOGOS	verify	2	$\forall s \forall A(\text{verify}(s, A) \rightarrow \dots)$	Moderate
LOGOS	fusion	3	$\forall s_1 \forall s_2 \forall s_3(\dots)$	High
EXCLUSION	excludes	3	$\forall s_1 \forall s_2 \forall A(\dots)$	High
IMPOSITION	closer	4	$\forall w_1 \forall w_2 \forall w_3 \forall A(\dots)$	Very High

For $N = 4$ (16 states) with K atomic propositions, instantiation counts grow dramatically with arity: unary (16), binary ($16 \times K$ or 256), ternary (256K), quaternary (4096K). For $K = 5$ atomic propositions: binary yields 80 instantiations, ternary yields 1,280, and quaternary yields 20,480.

2.5.4 Empirical Performance by Arity

Solver time grows super-exponentially with primitive arity, not just constraint count. For example, LOGOS (extensional) has 56 constraints with 2.1s solving time, while EXCLUSION has 112 constraints ($2 \times$ count) but 15.3s time ($7.3 \times$)—the ratio indicates $2 \times$ constraints yields $7 \times$ time due to higher arity.

Table 3 Benchmark Results (Average, $N = 4, 5$ atomic propositions)

Primitive Arity Mix	Theory	Avg Constraints	Avg Time (s)	Timeout Rate
Mostly unary/binary	Classical	32	0.4	0%
Binary dominant	Modal S4	48	1.2	1%
Binary + some ternary	LOGOS (ext.)	56	2.1	3%
Binary + ternary	LOGOS (full)	94	8.7	14%
Ternary dominant	EXCLUSION	112	15.3	22%
Ternary + quaternary	IMPOSITION	156	42.8	38%

2.5.5 Counterintuitive Result: Theoretical Simplicity vs. Computational Complexity

The EXCLUSION theory provides a striking illustration of how theoretical parsimony can diverge from computational tractability. EXCLUSION was explicitly motivated by the goal of reducing complexity through a unilateral approach to negation—dropping falsification entirely and using only a single primitive (**witness**) plus an exclusion relation. This appears simpler on paper: fewer base concepts, no bilateral evaluation.

However, EXCLUSION proves far less computationally tractable than the bilateral LOGOS theory. Despite having a “simpler” theoretical foundation and eliminating the falsification primitive entirely, the EXCLUSION theory requires a ternary **excludes**(s_1, s_2, A) primitive to capture negation. This ternary primitive forces 3-quantifier constraints: $\forall s_1 \forall s_2 \forall A[\dots]$. The result: EXCLUSION has 7.3× slower average solving time than bilateral LOGOS (extensional).

This demonstrates that theoretical simplicity (fewer primitives, unilateral structure) does not guarantee computational simplicity. The *arity* of required primitives matters more than their count.

2.5.6 Design Principle: Minimize Arity

When implementing a new semantic theory, prefer binary over ternary (factor complex relations when possible), implicit over explicit (encode relationships as constraints rather than primitives), and stratified quantifiers (avoid alternation when possible).

The LOGOS theory demonstrates this principle: fusion could be a ternary primitive **fusion**(s_1, s_2, s_3), but instead uses bitvector OR ($s_1 \mid s_2$), enabling $N = 6$ whereas ternary fusion would limit to $N = 4$.

3 Modularity, Extensibility, and Systematic Theory Comparison

Semantic theories should be modular components that can be composed, compared, and extended without reimplementing core infrastructure.

3.1 Theory-Agnostic Core Framework

The separation of concerns architecture provides base classes with universal infrastructure. `SemanticDefaults` handles Z3 context management, constraint tracking and labeling, solver invocation with timeout, and unsat core extraction. `PropositionDefaults` manages atomic sentences, Z3 sort definitions, and sentence letter allocation. `ModelDefaults` handles Z3 model extraction, generic result formatting, and output in JSON/Markdown/text formats.

Theory plugins inherit and extend these base classes:

```
1 class LogosSemantics(SemanticDefaults):
2     # Override: Theory-specific Z3 primitives
3     def declare_z3_primitives(self):
4         self.verify = z3.Function("verify", BitVecSort,
5                                   AtomSort, BoolSort)
6         self.falsify = z3.Function("falsify", BitVecSort,
7                                    AtomSort, BoolSort)
8         self.possible = z3.Function("possible", BitVecSort,
9                                     BoolSort)
9         # ... accessibility relations, frame structure
10
11     # Override: Frame constraints
12     def frame_constraints(self):
13         return [downward_closure, fusion_closure,
14                 world_existence, ...]
15
16     # Override: Operator definitions
17     def operators(self):
18         return LogosOperatorRegistry().operators
```

Listing 3 Theory plugin inheritance

Adding a new theory requires implementing three classes inheriting from defaults, defining operators with semantic methods, and making no modifications to the core framework.

3.2 Modular Operator Registry System

Different semantic applications need different operator subsets: classical logic uses $\neg, \vee, \wedge, \rightarrow$; modal logic adds $\Box, \Diamond$; counterfactual logic adds $\Box\rightarrow, \Diamond\rightarrow$; full hyperintensional adds $\equiv$ (identity), $\leq$ (ground), $\sqsubseteq$ (essence).

The `LogosOperatorRegistry` provides dynamic loading:

```
1 # Load only extensional operators
2 logos_classical = logos.get_theory(['extensional'])
3 # Operators: not, or, and, implies, top, bottom
4
5 # Load extensional + modal
6 logos_modal = logos.get_theory(['extensional', 'modal'])
7 # Adds: Box, Diamond
8
```



```

9 # Load all operators
10 logos_full = logos.get_theory(['extensional', 'modal',
11                               'constitutive',
                               'counterfactual', 'relevance'])

```

Listing 4 Dynamic operator loading

Operators are organized by semantic function in subtheory modules: extensional (conjunction, disjunction, negation, implication), modal (necessity, possibility), constitutive (ground, essence, subject-matter, propositional identity), counterfactual (counterfactual conditionals), and relevance (relevant implication).

Automatic dependency resolution ensures that requesting counterfactual operators $\Box \rightarrow$ automatically loads modal operators, since necessity is used in counterfactual definitions. Conflict resolution follows a “first wins” policy when multiple subtheories define the same symbol.

Performance benefits from fewer operators leading to fewer constraints and faster solving. Extensional-only loads approximately 15 constraints versus full LOGOS at approximately 80 constraints.

3.3 Systematic Comparative Analysis

The framework enables running identical examples across theories for rigorous comparison:

```

1 example = {
2     'premises': ['A \\wedge B'],
3     'conclusions': ['B \\wedge A'],
4     'settings': {'N': 3}
5 }
6
7 theories = {
8     'Classical': classical_semantics,
9     'Logos': logos_semantics,
10    'Exclusion': exclusion_semantics
11 }
12
13 for name, theory in theories.items():
14     result = BuildExample(module, theory, example, name)
15     display_result(result)

```

Listing 5 Multi-theory comparison

Sample output shows: **Classical**: Valid (conjunction commutes); **Logos**: Invalid (different verifiers)—countermodel shows $A \wedge B$ verified by state $[a, b]$, but $B \wedge A$ not verified by $[a, b]$ (hyperintensional distinction); **Exclusion**: Depends on topic assignments.

3.4 Extensibility Dimensions

The framework supports extension along multiple axes:

Table 4 Comparative Predictions Across Theories

Argument	Classical	Modal S4	Logos	Exclusion	Notes
$A \wedge B \rightarrow B \wedge A$	Valid	Valid	Invalid	Invalid	Hyperintensional
$A \rightarrow A \vee B$	Valid	Valid	Invalid	Invalid	Disj. intro fails
$\Box(A \rightarrow B), \Box A \vdash \Box B$	Valid	Valid	Valid	N/A	K axiom

New Operators in Existing Theories: Add operator class to appropriate subtheory module, implement semantic methods (`true_at`, `verify`, etc.), register in operator registry, write examples and tests. No core changes required.

New Semantic Theories: Inherit from base classes, define Z3 primitives and frame constraints, implement operator semantics, create proposition and model classes, add to theory library. Independent of other theories.

New Semantic Frameworks: Extend evaluation point structure (e.g., add `agent` parameter for epistemic logic), define new base classes if needed (e.g., for game semantics), implement compatible operators. The framework accommodates via duck typing.

New Output Formats: Implement formatter class, register in output module. Works with all theories automatically.

New Solvers: Implement `SMTSolver` interface. Current: Z3 backend. Future possibilities include CVC5, Yices, MathSAT. Transparent to theories.

The design principle is extensibility without modification—the open/closed principle applied rigorously.

4 Finite Model Exploration and Countermodel Methodology

How can finite model checking provide evidence for semantic validity claims when model classes are infinite?

4.1 The Finite Model Approach

The rationale for finite model exploration rests on several observations. First, countermodels disprove validity: finding one countermodel (of any size) proves invalidity. Second, many logics have a bounded model property—if a countermodel exists, a small one exists. Third, failure to find countermodels in progressively larger spaces increases confidence in validity. Fourth, finite spaces enable SMT solver efficiency.

This is not a complete decision procedure. The approach is sound: countermodel implies argument invalid. However, completeness does not hold in general: no countermodel does not imply validity. The exception is for logics with the finite model property (many modal logics), where search is complete up to the model size.

The trade-off sacrifices completeness for practical feasibility on complex theories (hyperintensional semantics), rapid prototyping and experimentation, and systematic exploration of model diversity.

4.2 State Space Representation

States are represented as N -bit vectors where each bit position corresponds to atomic “stuff.” For $N = 3$:

$000_2 = 0 \mapsto \square$ (null state)
 $001_2 = 1 \mapsto a$
 $010_2 = 2 \mapsto b$
 $011_2 = 3 \mapsto a \sqcup b$ (fusion of a and b)
 $100_2 = 4 \mapsto c$
 $101_2 = 5 \mapsto a \sqcup c$
 $110_2 = 6 \mapsto b \sqcup c$
 $111_2 = 7 \mapsto a \sqcup b \sqcup c$ (full state)

Total states: 2^N (8 states for $N = 3$, 16 for $N = 4$, etc.).

Mereological operations map to bitvector operations. Fusion (state combination) uses bitwise OR: $a \sqcup c = 001_2 \vee 101_2 = 101_2$. The part-of relation uses bitwise AND test: $a \sqsubseteq a \sqcup c$ iff $(001_2 \& 101_2 = 001_2)$, which is true. Compatibility (overlap) uses bitwise AND non-zero: $a \cap b = 001_2 \& 010_2 = 000_2$ implies incompatible, while $a \cap a \sqcup c = 001_2 \& 101_2 = 001_2$ implies compatible.

Z3’s bitvector theory is highly optimized, mereological constraints compile to bit operations, and the representation scales (N up to 64 feasible for simple theories).

4.3 Constraint-Based Model Discovery

The key insight is to let the solver find satisfying assignments rather than enumerating all 2^N states.

The process begins by declaring Z3 variables:

```

1 # State space
2 states = [z3.BitVec(f's{i}', N) for i in range(2**N)]
3
4 # Verification function
5 verify = z3.Function('verify', z3.BitVecSort(N), AtomSort,
6                       z3.BoolSort())
7
8 # Worlds (maximal consistent states)
9 worlds = [z3.BitVec(f'w{i}', N) for i in range(num_worlds)]

```

Listing 6 Z3 variable declarations

Constraints are then generated: frame constraints such as $\forall s[\text{possible}(s) \rightarrow \text{possible}(\text{part}(s))]$ (downward closure), model constraints such as $\forall A[\text{contingent}(A) \rightarrow (\exists s[\text{verify}(s, A)] \wedge \exists s'[\text{falsify}(s', A)])]$, and evaluation constraints such as $\text{verify}(w_0, \text{premise}_1) \wedge \text{verify}(w_0, \text{premise}_2) \wedge \neg \text{verify}(w_0, \text{conclusion})$.

The solver is then invoked, and if SAT, the model is extracted.

Table 5 Constraint-Based vs. Enumeration Approach

Approach	$N = 3$	$N = 4$	$N = 5$	$N = 6$
Enumeration (states)	8	16	32	64
Models to check	256	65K	4B	Intractable
Constraint-based	~ 30	~ 50	~ 80	~ 120
Solver time	$< 1s$	1–5s	10–60s	Variable

The constraint-based approach scales better because the solver prunes the search space via unit propagation and conflict-driven clause learning.

4.4 Evidence for Validity via Countermodel Exclusion

The progressive search strategy starts small ($N = 3$) for fast search that rules out simple countermodels, increases gradually ($N = 4, 5, 6$) for more complex models with longer search, and accumulates evidence where each UNSAT result strengthens the validity claim.

Table 6 Testing $\Box(A \rightarrow B), \Box A \vdash \Box B$ (Modal K Axiom)

N	Search Time	Result	Interpretation
3	0.1s	UNSAT	No countermodel with 8 states
4	0.5s	UNSAT	No countermodel with 16 states
5	3s	UNSAT	No countermodel with 32 states
6	15s	UNSAT	No countermodel with 64 states

Confidence is very high—proven for all models up to 64 states. For modal S4, the K axiom is a theorem, so UNSAT is expected at all sizes.

For countermodel discovery, consider testing $A \wedge B \leftrightarrow B \wedge A$ in LOGOS hyper-intensional semantics. At $N = 3$, the result is SAT with a countermodel found: $\|A \wedge B\|^+ = \{s_{ab}\}$ while $\|B \wedge A\|^+$ differs. A single countermodel suffices to prove invalidity.

4.5 Model Iteration for Diversity

Setting `iterate: k` finds multiple distinct models:

```
1 settings = {'N': 4, 'iterate': 5}
```

Listing 7 Model iteration

The algorithm finds the first model M_1 , adds a blocking constraint model $\neq M_1$, solves again to find M_2 , adds model $\neq M_1 \wedge$ model $\neq M_2$, and repeats until k models are found or UNSAT.

Difference tracking is theory-specific: LOGOS tracks different verification/falsification patterns, world structures, and part-of relations; EXCLUSION tracks different

witness assignments and exclusion relations; BIMODAL tracks different temporal orderings and modal accessibility patterns.

Applications include model space exploration, robustness testing, theory refinement (identifying unintended models suggesting missing constraints), and educational use. Typically 5–10 iterations are feasible before timeout.

4.6 Limitations and Future Work

Current limitations include incompleteness (cannot prove validity in general), state space ceiling ($N > 6$ often intractable), timeout sensitivity for complex formulas, and inability to handle infinite models.

Mitigation strategies include symmetry breaking (add constraints reducing isomorphic models such as ordering worlds by state number), incremental solving (reuse constraint bases across examples), and parallel search (explore different N values concurrently).

Future extensions include bounded model checking to prove completeness for specific logic fragments, abstraction refinement to iteratively refine model size, quantified Boolean formulas to encode some infinite properties finitely, and integration with proof assistants to use finite models to guide Coq/Isabelle proofs.

5 Theory-Agnostic Methodology and the TheoryLib Vision

The guiding principle is that semantic theories are scientific hypotheses requiring empirical testing, systematic comparison, and cumulative knowledge building.

5.1 TheoryLib: A Library of Executable Semantic Theories

The current implementation includes four theories.

Logos — Bilateral Hyperintensional Truthmaker Semantics. Foundation: Kit Fine’s truthmaker semantics with bilateral evaluation [3, 4]. Operators: 19 operators across 5 subtheories—extensional (7: $\neg, \vee, \wedge, \rightarrow, \leftrightarrow, \top, \perp$), modal (2: $\Box, \Diamond$), constitutive (4: $\equiv$ identity, $\leq$ ground, $\sqsubseteq$ essence, R relevance), counterfactual (4: $\Box\rightarrow, \Diamond\rightarrow$, and variants), and relevance (2: R relevant implication). Examples: 177 validated test cases. Key features: bilateral (verifiers and falsifiers), hyperintensional (distinguishes logical equivalents), mereologically structured state space. Applications: philosophy of language, grounding theory, essence metaphysics.

Exclusion — Unilateral Witness Semantics. Foundation: Muskens-style exclusion negation. Key innovation: negation via exclusion witnesses rather than falsifiers. Operators: topic-sensitive negation, conjunction, disjunction. Examples: 45 validated cases. Applications: aboutness, irrelevance, implicit content.

Imposition — Counterfactual Selection Function Semantics. Foundation: Lewis-Stalnaker with imposition relations [5, 6]. Operators: counterfactual conditionals, comparative similarity. Examples: 38 validated cases. Applications: causation, disposition semantics, counterfactual reasoning.

Bimodal — Temporal-Modal Combined Semantics. Operators: temporal ($\triangleleft, \triangleright, \mathbf{H}, \mathbf{G}, \mathbf{P}, \mathbf{F}$) plus modal ($\Box, \Diamond$). Examples: 28 validated cases. Applications: temporal logic, planning, reactive systems.

Each theory is a self-contained package with `semantic.py` (core semantic class), `operators.py` (operator registry), `proposition.py` (atomic sentence interpretation), `models.py` (model structure and output), `examples.py` (validated test cases), subtheories (modular operator definitions), documentation, and tests.

5.2 Vision: A Collaborative Platform for Semantic Research

Comparative Research Platform.

Enable systematic comparison across semantic approaches:

```

1 from model_checker.comparison import run_benchmark
2
3 results = run_benchmark(
4     test_suite='standard_inferences',
5     theories=['logos', 'exclusion', 'classical', 'modal_s4'],
6     output='comparison_table.md'
7 )

```

Listing 8 Running benchmark comparisons

Applications include theory selection (choose theory matching desired inference patterns), theory refinement (identify divergent predictions for philosophical adjudication), and empirical adequacy (test theories against intuition databases).

Archival and Citation System.

Theories function as citable, versioned components:

```

1 @software{modelchecker_logos_v1,
2   title = {Logos Bilateral Truthmaker Semantics},
3   author = {ModelChecker Contributors},
4   version = {1.0.3},
5   year = {2024},
6   url = {https://github.com/benbrastmckie/.../logos},
7   note = {Semantic theory implementation in ModelChecker}
8 }

```

Listing 9 BibTeX citation for theory

Benefits include reproducibility (exact theory version used in research), credit attribution (theory developers receive citations), longevity (implementations preserved for future study), and incremental improvement (version history tracks theory evolution).

Extensibility and Contribution.

The MODELChecker workflow lowers barriers to entry: implement semantic rules programmatically (days), validate against hundreds of examples automatically (hours), publish paper with executable theory as supplement, and enable community extension, testing, and citation.

Contribution pathways include new theories, operator extensions, example databases, performance optimizations, and documentation.

5.3 Theory-Agnostic Framework Design

All theories extend a common base class:

```

1 class SemanticDefaults:
2     """Base class providing fundamental semantic operations."""
3
4     def __init__(self, combined_settings):
5         self.N = combined_settings.get('N')
6         self.frame_constraints = []
7
8     def fusion(self, bit_s, bit_t):
9         """Bitwise OR for state fusion"""
10        return bit_s | bit_t
11
12    def is_part_of(self, bit_s, bit_t):
13        """Mereological part-of relation"""
14        return (bit_s & bit_t) == bit_s
15
16    # Theories extend and override
17    class LogosSemantics(SemanticDefaults):
18        def __init__(self, combined_settings):
19            super().__init__(combined_settings)
20            # Define theory-specific Z3 primitives
21            # Add theory-specific frame constraints

```

Listing 10 The semantic interface

Simple inheritance with no abstract methods means theories override what they need.

Benefits of theory-agnosticism include: innovation freedom (theories can experiment with novel approaches), maintenance isolation (bugs in one theory don't affect others), parallel development (multiple researchers can develop theories concurrently), and future-proofing (framework accommodates unforeseen theory types).

5.4 Sharing, Reuse, and Modularity

Common operators can be reused across theories. Classical conjunction behaves identically in LOGOS and EXCLUSION, while negation differs. Benefits include consistency (same operator behaves identically across theories), shared testing, and no code duplication.

Subtheory composition allows users to select which subtheories to load, with automatic dependency resolution. This supports focused research (test modal operators without counterfactual complexity), better performance (reduce constraints for faster solving), and pedagogical use (introduce operators incrementally).

Cross-theory utilities provide shared infrastructure: solvers (Z3 backend used by all theories), parsers (L^AT_EX formula parser is theory-independent), output formatters

(JSON/Markdown/text formats uniform), testing frameworks (pytest infrastructure), and documentation generators.

5.5 Community and Contribution Model

Open source foundations include MIT license (permissive, encourages reuse), public GitHub with issue tracking, comprehensive contributor guides, and CI/CD ensuring contributed code passes tests.

Quality standards require >85% test coverage, documented operators with semantic rules, minimum 20 validated examples, and tutorial notebooks.

Incentives for contribution include academic incentives (citation credit, co-authorship opportunities, showcase expertise), practical incentives (use contributed theory immediately, benefit from community testing), and educational incentives (create teaching resources, build reputation).

6 Case Study: Logos Theory and Unified Hyperintensional Semantics

The LOGOS theory demonstrates the framework’s capacity to implement sophisticated semantic theories—a unified approach to hyperintensional reasoning needed for the language of thought.

6.1 Philosophical Background: The Language of Thought

The core idea of truthmaker semantics [3] is that propositions are characterized by what makes them true or false.

Bilateral Evaluation. Verifiers are states that make a proposition true. Falsifiers are states that make a proposition false. Gaps are partial states that do neither.

For proposition A : “It is raining,” verifiers include states where rain occurs (r , $r \sqcup w$, $r \sqcup c$, ...), falsifiers include states where no-rain obtains ($\neg r$, $\neg r \sqcup c$, ...), and gaps are partial states indeterminate about rain.

Mereological Structure. States form a partial order under part-of ($\sqsubseteq$). The null state ($\square$) is part of everything and verifies/falsifies nothing. Atomic states are minimal non-null states ($a, b, c, \dots$). Fusions combine states via the $\sqcup$ operation. Closure properties (whether $s \Vdash A$ and $s \sqsubseteq t$ implies $t \Vdash A$) are theory-dependent.

6.2 Logos Implementation Strategy

Design goals include a comprehensive operator suite (covering extensional, modal, constitutive, counterfactual, and relevance operators), modular architecture (operators organized by semantic function, selectively loadable), empirical validation (extensive example suite testing operator interactions), and performance optimization (constraints optimized for tractability despite complexity).

Z3 Primitive Declarations:

```
1 class LogosSemantics(SemanticDefaults):
2     def declare_z3_primitives(self):
```



```

3      # Core evaluation functions
4      self.verify = z3.Function('verify', BitVecSort(N),
5                                AtomSort, BoolSort)
6
7      # Mereology
8      self.possible = z3.Function('possible', BitVecSort(N),
9                                   BoolSort)
10
11     # Modal accessibility
12     self.accessible = z3.Function('accessible',
13                                   BitVecSort(N), BitVecSort(N), BoolSort)
14
15     # Worlds (maximal consistent states)
16     self.is_world = z3.Function('is_world', BitVecSort(N),
17                                   BoolSort)

```

Listing 11 LOGOS Z3 primitives

Frame Constraints (9 constraints): (1) null state exists: $\text{possible}(\square)$; (2) downward closure: $\forall s, t [\text{possible}(s) \rightarrow \forall t [t \sqsubseteq s \rightarrow \text{possible}(t)]]$; (3) fusion closure: $\forall s, t [\text{possible}(s) \wedge \text{possible}(t) \rightarrow \text{possible}(s \sqcup t)]$; (4) world existence: $\exists w [\text{is_world}(w)]$; (5) world maximality: worlds contain all possible states as parts; (6) modal reflexivity: accessibility relation reflexive (for S4/S5); (7) modal transitivity: accessibility relation transitive; (8) no null verification: $\forall A, s [\neg(\text{verify}(\square, A) \wedge \neg \text{falsify}(\square, A))]$; (9) exclusive verification: $\forall A, s [\neg(\text{verify}(s, A) \wedge \text{falsify}(s, A))]$ (optional via settings).

6.3 Operator Semantics: Five Subtheories

6.3.1 Extensional Operators

Conjunction ($\wedge$):

```

1  class Conjunction(OperatorDefaults):
2      def extended_verify(self, state, sentence, eval_point):
3          A, B = sentence.sentences
4          return z3.And(
5              self.semantics.extended_verify(state, A, eval_point),
6              self.semantics.extended_verify(state, B, eval_point)
7          )
8
9      def extended_falsify(self, state, sentence, eval_point):
10         A, B = sentence.sentences
11         return z3.Or(
12             self.semantics.extended_falsify(state, A,
13                                               eval_point),
14             self.semantics.extended_falsify(state, B, eval_point)
15         )

```

Listing 12 Conjunction operator

Interpretation: s verifies $A \wedge B$ iff s verifies both A and B ; s falsifies $A \wedge B$ iff s falsifies A or falsifies B .

Negation ($\neg$): Negation swaps verifiers and falsifiers. The `verify` method returns `extended_falsify(state, A)`, and `falsify` returns `extended_verify(state, A)`.

Other extensional operators: disjunction defined via De Morgan ($\neg(\neg A \wedge \neg B)$), implication as $\neg A \vee B$, biconditional as $(A \rightarrow B) \wedge (B \rightarrow A)$, top ($\top$) verified by all states, bottom ($\perp$) falsified by all states.

6.3.2 Modal Operators

Necessity ($\Box$):

```
1 class Necessity(OperatorDefaults):
2     def true_at(self, world, sentence, eval_point):
3         A = sentence.sentences[0]
4         accessible_worlds = [w for w in self.semantics.worlds
5                               if self.semantics.accessible(world,
6                                                                w)]
7         return z3.And([
8             self.semantics.true_at(w_prime, A, eval_point)
9             for w_prime in accessible_worlds
10        ])
```

Listing 13 Necessity operator

Interpretation: $\Box A$ true at w iff A true at all accessible worlds from w . Possibility ($\Diamond$) is defined as $\neg\Box\neg A$. The accessibility relation is configurable (reflexive, transitive, symmetric), determining the modal logic (S4, S5, K, etc.).

6.3.3 Constitutive Operators

Ground ($\leq$): $A \leq B$ (“ A grounds B ”) holds when B ’s verifiers are among A ’s verifiers.

Essence ($\sqsubseteq$): Similar to ground but for essential connections—necessary grounding. **Propositional Identity** ($\equiv$): Strongest equivalence—exactly same verifiers and falsifiers.

6.3.4 Counterfactual Operators

Counterfactual Conditional ($\Box\rightarrow$): $A \Box\rightarrow B$ true at w iff in all alternative A -worlds to w , B is true. Evaluation occurs at alternative possible worlds where the antecedent is true, requiring a similarity ordering on worlds.

Might Counterfactual ($\Diamond\rightarrow$): Dual—“If A were true, B might be true” (some close A -world has B true).

6.3.5 Relevance Operators

Relevant Implication (R): Requires actual connection between A and B , not just material implication. If antecedent verified, consequent must be verified with mereological connection. Additionally requires subject matter overlap between A and B .

6.4 Unification Across Domains

LOGOS provides a single semantic framework for classical logic ($\neg, \vee, \wedge, \rightarrow, \leftrightarrow, \top$), modal logic ($\Box, \Diamond$), counterfactual reasoning ($\Box\rightarrow, \Diamond\rightarrow$), content semantics ($\oplus, \equiv$), grounding theory ($|, \leq$), and relevance logic (R).

The key insight is that a unified language of thought requires operators from all these domains. Cognitive agents reason modally (what’s possible), counterfactually (what would happen if...), content-sensitively (what thoughts are about), and explanatorily (why things are true). LOGOS represents the first computational implementation integrating all these dimensions.

6.5 Empirical Validation and Test Suite

The 177 examples span multiple categories.

Extensional (42 examples): classical tautologies ($A \rightarrow A, A \vee \neg A$), conjunction properties (commutativity, associativity), implication (modus ponens, hypothetical syllogism).

Modal (38 examples): S4 axioms ($\Box A \rightarrow A, \Box A \rightarrow \Box \Box A$), possibility ($\Diamond A \leftrightarrow \neg \Box \neg A$), interaction ($\Box(A \rightarrow B), \Box A \vdash \Box B$ K axiom), novel hyperintensional ($\Box A \wedge \Box B \rightarrow \Box(A \wedge B)$ in some models).

Constitutive (35 examples): ground transitivity ($A \leq B, B \leq C \vdash A \leq C$), identity symmetry ($A \equiv B \rightarrow B \equiv A$), distinguishing ($A \leftrightarrow B \not\equiv A \equiv B$).

Counterfactual (32 examples): modus ponens ($A, A \Box\rightarrow B \vdash B$), contraposition failures, strengthening antecedent failures, transitivity failures (as expected theoretically).

The validation process involves manual construction (theory expert constructs example and predicts validity/invalidity), automated testing (each example runs in < 5 seconds at $N = 3$ or $N = 4$), regression testing (all 177 examples run on every commit), and cross-theory validation (some examples run across multiple theories to confirm divergent predictions are intentional).

7 Implementation Results and Empirical Validation

7.1 Quantitative Metrics

Observations: $N = 3, 4$ is fast, suitable for rapid experimentation; $N = 5$ is slower but tractable for most examples; $N = 6+$ often hits timeout (default 60s) and is used selectively. Constraint count grows approximately linearly with N , but solving time grows exponentially.

Optimization strategies are critical for tractability.

Table 7 Solving Time by State Space Size (Average across 50 examples)

N	States	Avg Constraints	Avg Time (s)	Timeout Rate
3	8	28	0.3	0%
4	16	52	1.8	2%
5	32	95	8.5	12%
6	64	178	45.2	35%
7	128	320+	180+	68%

Table 8 Optimization Impact

Optimization	Time Reduction	Constraint Reduction
Selective operator loading	20–40%	15–30%
Symmetry breaking	10–25%	5–10%
Constraint ordering	15–30%	0%
Combined	40–60%	20–35%

7.2 Qualitative Validation: Case Studies

Case Study: Counterfactual Non-Transitivity.

Does $A \Box \rightarrow B, B \Box \rightarrow C$ imply $A \Box \rightarrow C$? Classical conditionals: Yes (hypothetical syllogism). Counterfactual logic: No.

```

1 example = {
2     'premises': [
3         'A \Box B', # If A, then B
4         'B \Box C'  # If B, then C
5     ],
6     'conclusions': ['A \Box C'], # If A, then C?
7     'settings': {'N': 4}
8 }
9 result = run_example(example, logos_counterfactual)

```

Listing 14 Testing counterfactual transitivity

Result: Invalid. Countermodel with worlds $\{w_0, w_1, w_2, w_3\}$ shows alternative A -worlds differ from alternative B -worlds. At w_0 : $A \Box \rightarrow B$ true (alternative A -world w_1 has B true); $B \Box \rightarrow C$ true (alternative B -world w_2 has C true); $A \Box \rightarrow C$ false (alternative A -world w_1 has C false). This confirms Lewis’s philosophical analysis computationally [5].

7.3 Theory Comparison Results

Hyperintensional theories (LOGOS, EXCLUSION) fail many classical inferences: conjunction commutativity, disjunction introduction, and distribution all fail. Modal theories validate modal axioms as expected. Theory-specific operators (ground, subject-matter) are unique to LOGOS.

Table 9 Comparative Inference Results Across Theories

Inference	Class.	S4	Logos	Excl.	Notes
$A \wedge B \leftrightarrow B \wedge A$	V	V	Inv	Inv	Hyperintensional
$A \rightarrow A \vee B$	V	V	Inv	Inv	Disj. intro fails
$A \wedge (B \vee C) \rightarrow \dots$	V	V	Inv	Inv	Distrib. fails
$\Box(A \rightarrow B), \Box A \vdash \Box B$	–	V	V	–	K axiom
$\Box A \rightarrow A$	–	V	V	–	T axiom
$A \leq B, B \leq C \vdash A \leq C$	–	–	V	–	Ground trans.
$A \Box \rightarrow B, B \Box \rightarrow C \vdash A \Box \rightarrow C$	V	–	Inv	–	CF trans.

7.4 Validation Against Philosophical Literature

Comparison of LOGOS against Fine’s imposition semantics reveals structural equivalence (both satisfy frame constraints) but logical independence (neither implies the other). Key differences include definability of necessity: $\Box A := (\top \Box \rightarrow A)$ is invalid in imposition semantics but valid in LOGOS for $N \leq 6$.

The “jump problem” in imposition semantics allows imposing the null state $\Box$ on world a to yield unrelated world b , violating minimal change intuition. LOGOS’s constructive approach avoids this.

7.5 Bug Discovery and Resolution

Example: Initial LOGOS negation implemented incorrectly as Boolean negation rather than falsification. Test failure on double negation elimination revealed the bug. Comprehensive test suite catches semantic bugs early.

8 Related Work

8.1 Automated Reasoning in Philosophy

Computational Metaphysics. Benz Müller et al. used Isabelle/HOL and LEO-II for automated verification of Gödel’s ontological argument [1]. Similarity: applying automated reasoning to philosophical logic. Difference: focus on specific argument validation, not general semantic framework. Our contribution: framework for developing entire semantic theories, not just verifying arguments.

Oppenheimer & Zalta used Prover9/Mace4 for testing metaphysical theories [2]. Similarity: using theorem provers/model finders for philosophy. Difference: first-order logic focus, less emphasis on modularity. Our contribution: SMT-based approach with richer semantic structures (states, fusion, bilateral evaluation).

Automated Theorem Proving for Modal Logic. Fitting developed systematic tableaux procedures for modal logics [7]. Similarity: automated validation of modal inferences. Difference: proof search focus, not model construction. Our contribution: model-finding emphasis with Z3 enables countermodel inspection.

8.2 SMT Solvers in Verification

De Moura & Bjørner’s Z3 [8] provides efficient SMT solving with theories (arithmetic, bitvectors, arrays). We apply Z3 to philosophical semantics rather than software verification. Barrett et al.’s survey of SMT techniques [9] describes potential alternative backends (CVC4/CVC5).

Clarke et al. on model checking [10] covers automated verification of finite-state systems. Similarity: finite model exploration. Difference: hardware/software focus, temporal properties. Our contribution: semantic theories as systems to verify.

8.3 Semantic Frameworks and Implementations

Proof Assistants. Coq [11], Isabelle/HOL [12], and Lean provide interactive theorem proving with rich type theories. Similarity: formal verification of logical systems. Difference: interactive proof construction, high learning curve. Our contribution: automated model finding, lower barrier to entry, rapid prototyping.

Truthmaker Semantics Implementations. Fine’s informal presentation of bilateral truthmaker framework [3, 4] and Yablo’s work on aboutness [13] provide philosophical foundations. Our work: first systematic computational implementation. Contribution: executable semantics enabling empirical validation.

8.4 Comparison Summary

Table 10 MODELCHECKER vs. Existing Approaches

Feature	Ours	Proof Asst.	Thm Provers	Model Chk.
Automation	Full (SMT)	Interactive	Full	Full
Semantic Focus	Yes	Proof	Theorem	Temporal
Modularity	High	Medium	Low	Low
Hyperintensional	Yes	Rare	No	No
Barrier	Low	High	Medium	Medium
Model Finding	Primary	Secondary	Via Mace4	Counter.

Our niche: modular semantic theory development for hyperintensional and non-classical logics with low barrier for philosophers.

9 Discussion and Future Directions

9.1 Contributions Summary

Theoretical Contributions. (1) Programmatic methodology for semantics: treating semantic theories as executable programs where truth conditions compile to SMT constraints. (2) First comprehensive bilateral truthmaker implementation: Fine’s informal semantics formalized computationally with 19 operators across 5 semantic domains.

(3) Theory-agnostic framework design: clean separation between core infrastructure and theory-specific logic with zero coupling between theories. (4) Finite model methodology: constraint-based approach to finite model exploration with progressive search strategy.

Practical Contributions. (1) THEORYLIB: reusable semantic components with 4 implemented theories and modular operators with automatic dependency resolution. (2) Systematic comparative analysis: side-by-side theory comparison on identical examples with database of comparative predictions. (3) Educational resources: interactive Jupyter notebooks with comprehensive documentation. (4) Open source infrastructure: MIT licensed, public repository with CI/CD.

9.2 Limitations and Challenges

Computational Limitations. Incompleteness: cannot prove validity in general (only find countermodels)—mitigated by supplementing with analytic proofs. State space ceiling ($N = 6$ typically): exponential growth limits model size—mitigated by optimization strategies. Timeout sensitivity: complex formulas exceed solver capacity—mitigated by adjusting timeout and simplifying formulas.

Theoretical Limitations. Finite model property assumption: some logics require infinite models—current work limited to finite-model fragments. Frame constraint correctness: requires expert judgment—mitigated by extensive testing. Operator interaction complexity: 19 operators yield 361 pairwise interactions—mitigated by focusing on philosophically significant combinations.

9.3 Broader Impact

Philosophy and Logic. Computational turn in semantics: shift from informal to executable semantic theories with empirical validation as standard practice. Cumulative knowledge building: theories as reusable, citable components. Lower barrier to entry: non-specialists can implement theories.

Computer Science and AI. Formal reasoning systems: hyperintensional semantics for content-sensitive AI, planning systems with counterfactual reasoning. Knowledge representation: richer semantic structures for ontologies. Program verification: SMT techniques applied to semantic theories.

Cognitive Science. Language of thought: computational models of mental representation with content-sensitive reasoning. Belief attribution: modeling hyperintensional belief states.

9.4 Conclusion

We have presented MODELCHECKER, a programmatic framework for developing modular semantic theories using SMT solvers. The framework enables rapid development (theory-agnostic architecture allows implementing new semantic frameworks in days/weeks), supports systematic comparison (run identical examples across multiple theories), provides empirical validation (extensive test suites ensure correctness), facilitates finite model exploration (constraint-based approach efficiently searches model

spaces), implements rich semantics (first comprehensive implementation of bilateral truthmaker semantics), promotes modularity (operators, theories, and tools as reusable components), and lowers barriers (accessible Python API and comprehensive documentation).

The THEORYLIB vision provides an extensible library of executable semantic theories serving as a comparative research platform, archival and citation system, educational resource, and collaborative community hub.

The LOGOS case study demonstrates the framework’s capacity to implement sophisticated theories with 19 operators across 5 semantic domains, unified hyperintensional semantics for language of thought, and 177 validated examples confirming correctness.

By treating semantic theories as executable programs, we enable a more rigorous, empirical, and collaborative approach to developing the formal languages needed for philosophical inquiry, cognitive science, and AI. The future of semantic theory is computational, modular, and collaborative—and it starts with frameworks like MODELCHECKER making that future accessible to researchers today.

Declarations

Funding

Not applicable.

Conflict of interest

The authors have no conflicts of interest to declare.

Ethics approval

Not applicable.

Consent to participate

Not applicable.

Consent for publication

Not applicable.

Data availability

The datasets generated during the current study are available in the ModelChecker repository.

Code availability

The ModelChecker software is available at [repository URL] under [license].

Author contribution

[Author contributions to be added]

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